

THE LONE WOMAN OF SAN NICOLAS ISLAND

The Nicoleno Indians had occupied San Nicolas Island for many centuries before their first contact with Europeans. Beginning about 1811, sea otter hunting expeditions headed by Russian, American, and British companies began to visit the island. These expeditions utilized primarily Aleut hunters. Aleuts are a native American group from the Aleutian Islands in Alaska. Reportedly, hostilities developed between the Aleuts and the Nicolenos with the result that by 1835 only about a half dozen Nicolenos were left. In that year, the padres of Mission San Gabriel, decided to remove the Nicolenos to the mainland. The mission fathers chartered the schooner Peor es nada, for the job.

When Captain Hubbard and the Peor es nada reached San Nicolas Island, there were only about four adult Nicolenos left. He gathered up the remaining residents. A violent storm came up and the ship had to leave immediately or face certain destruction. In the commotion, one woman was left behind. It is unclear why she was left behind. There is one story that she had gotten aboard the ship and had to jump overboard, and swim back to the island, when she realized that her child had not been brought aboard. Most reliable accounts, however, say that she was inadvertently left behind when she went back to camp to find her child. Whatever the reason, she was left behind and spent the next 18 years in total isolation on a small desert island.

Capt. Hubbard had wished to return to the island and retrieve the Lone Woman, but other obligations took him away. During one of his trips, the Peor es Nada was wrecked near the Golden Gate off San Francisco.

What happened to her and how she lived during those 18 years will never be known. She undoubtedly learned to fend for herself learning many of the skills which were usually reserved for the men. Gathering food and water would have occupied much of her time. Making and mending clothing and tools would also have been endless chores.

Along the entire coast it was known that an Indian woman had been left alone on the island, but it was not possible to rescue her or learn of her fate. For many years after the loss of the Peor es Nada, the only sailing craft on the coast were small boats. The long distance and rough seas of the outer Channel Islands would have rendered such a trip extremely dangerous in such small boats. As the years passed by, all agreed that she must have perished. Sea otter hunters continued to visit the island occasionally and there were persistent rumors that the woman was still alive and had been sighted on occasion.

In 1853, George Nidever, a Santa Barbara entrepreneur, decided that the only way to know for sure if the woman was still alive, would be to systematically search the island for her. Nidever arranged an otter hunting expedition to the island with extra time set aside to search the island for the Lone Woman.

During one of his searches, Nidever found a basket full of tools and trinkets that he felt must belong to the Lone Woman. He emptied the contents of the basket on the ground with the idea that if the woman were still alive, she would find her possessions on the ground, and place them back into the basket. When Nidever returned to the site a few days later, he found that the objects had been returned to the basket. With this, he was confident that the woman was still alive.

Nidever and his men started to search the entire island. They started at the east end and worked their way toward the west end searching all of the country in between. One of the men finally spotted her near the west tip of the island on top of a sand dune. She was inside a brush hut made from a framework of whale bones. The group slowly converged on the woman. The woman didn't run off as they thought she might. Instead, she seemed almost glad to see people again after 18 lonely years. She prepared a meal for the men and collected a few of her possessions for her trip.

Nidever brought the woman back to Santa Barbara where he and his wife could care for her. The story of her discovery spread, and the curious came from miles around to see the Lone Woman. A desperate attempt was made to locate someone who could communicate with her, but no one could be found who spoke the Nicoleno language. All of the Nicolenos removed from the island in 1835 had died by this time.

Ultimately, civilization proved to be a greater challenge to her than life alone on San Nicolas Island. Her good health soon failed, probably due to the different diet and exposure to European diseases to which she had no immunity. Within a few weeks it was evident that she was dying. On her deathbed she was baptised with the name 'Juana Maria'. She was buried in the cemetery at Mission Santa Barbara. With her passing, so ended the culture of the Channel Islands Indians.

A fictionalized account of the Lone Woman's plight can be read in the novel, Island of the Blue Dolphin by Scott O'Dell. A feature length motion picture was also made from the novel by Universal Studios which is now available on video tape.